



BBQ Cook Times

A pocket-ready reference for safe temperatures, pitmaster finish cues, and better cook notes.

TWO NUMBERS MATTER Safety temperature first. Texture temperature second.

Confusing them is how people get sick - or serve tough brisket. Use a calibrated probe thermometer.

1. SAFE MINIMUM INTERNAL TEMPERATURE

USDA FSIS food-safety minimums. Measure in the thickest part, away from bone and fat.

Food	Minimum	Notes
Poultry, all of it	165 F / 74 C	Whole birds, pieces, ground poultry and stuffing. No rest required.
Ground meats	160 F / 71 C	Beef, pork, veal and lamb once ground.
Beef, pork, veal, lamb	145 F / 63 C	Steaks, chops and roasts, PLUS a 3 minute rest before carving.
Fresh or smoked ham, uncooked	145 F / 63 C	Plus a 3 minute rest.
Fully cooked ham, reheating	165 F / 74 C	140 F if it was packaged at a USDA-inspected plant.
Fish and shellfish	145 F / 63 C	Or until flesh is opaque and separates.
Egg dishes	160 F / 71 C	
Leftovers and casseroles	165 F / 74 C	

COLOR IS NOT DONENESS

A cooked burger can stay pink and an undercooked one can look brown; only a thermometer tells you. Safe minimum internal temperatures are from the USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service, Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart.



Cook to Feel, Not the Clock

Safety sets the floor. Texture, tenderness, bark, and rest determine the finish.

2. TEXTURE TEMPERATURE = PREFERENCE

PITMASTER CONVENTION - NOT A FOOD SAFETY STANDARD

Tough cuts often cook beyond the safety minimum for tenderness. Times and finish temperatures are planning guides; the USDA minimum always governs.

Cut	Pit temp	Rough time	Finish by
Brisket, packer	225-250 F	10-16 h	195-205 F, probe slides in like soft butter. Rest 1-2 h.
Pork shoulder / Boston butt	225-275 F	8-14 h	200-205 F for pulling. Rest 1 h minimum.
Pork spare ribs	225-250 F	5-6 h	Bend test: bark cracks when lifted. Roughly 195-203 F.
Baby back ribs	225-250 F	4-5 h	Bend test, same as above.
Beef short ribs	250-275 F	6-8 h	Probe tender, roughly 203 F.
Whole chicken	300-350 F	2-3 h	165 F breast MINIMUM. Higher pit temp for crisp skin.
Chicken thighs	275-325 F	1.5-2 h	Safe at 165 F, but 175-180 F renders better.
Turkey breast	300-325 F	2-3 h	165 F. Do not push it further, it dries.
Pork loin	250 F	2-3 h	145 F plus a 3 minute rest. It is lean, it will not take more.
Salmon	225 F	45-60 min	125-145 F depending on how you like it; 145 F is the safe figure.

TIMING RULE

Times assume a steady pit and are planning estimates only. Start earlier than you think.

THE STALL

Around 150-170 F a large cut stops climbing, sometimes for hours. That is evaporative cooling, not a broken cooker. Wait it out, or wrap in foil or butcher paper to push through.

Wrapping is faster and softens bark; waiting keeps bark firmer. A finished brisket can rest for hours; an unfinished one cannot.



Cook Log

The reference helps once. The log helps you repeat what worked.

DATE	CUT / WEIGHT	PIT TEMP	ON	WRAPPED AT	OFF	FINAL TEMP	REST	WOOD	RESULT

SAFETY WINS

Safe minimum internal temperatures are from USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service.

Texture temperatures, pit temperatures and times are barbecue convention and personal preference - NOT food safety guidance.

Where the two differ, the USDA minimum governs. Use a calibrated probe thermometer.

KEEP THE LOG GOING



pitlog.app

Open the digital log
and keep your cook
history in one place.